piece of social engineering that yielded a rich haul for the BSP in 2007—collapsed. After the infamous Vikas Dubey encounter in Kanpur in 2020, Mayawati had entrusted the responsibility of wooing the Brahmin community to Mishra. At the 65-odd *prabuddh sammelans* (intellectual gatherings) that he organised, Mishra would claim that if the 13 per cent Brahmins joined the BSP, then along with the 20-21 per cent Dalits, BSP's victory was assured. Riding this optimism, the party gave tickets to 65 Brahmins, of which more than half could not even save their deposits. Baidyanath Tiwari, who runs an organisation called Brahman Jago Manch in Varanasi, says, "Mayawati's politics is based only on calculation. She considers Brahmins as just a votebank. She gave Satish Mishra the responsibility of wooing the Brahmins just before the election. The Brahmins have now wised up to her tricks."

The Muslims, too, chose to repose their faith in the SP, amid allegations that Mayawati had cut a deal with the BJP in a bid to deflect the disproportionate assets cases against her and brother Anand Kumar. In 2019, the income tax department had attached a 'benami' property in Noida which was allegedly in Anand and his wife's names. The SP and BSP, who had fought the 2019 LS election together, had a bitter parting after the loss, with Mayawati accusing Akhilesh's party of weighing down the BSP's prospects. This time, the BSP fielded the maximum number of Muslim candidates—89—in the hope of cutting into the SP's Muslim vote.

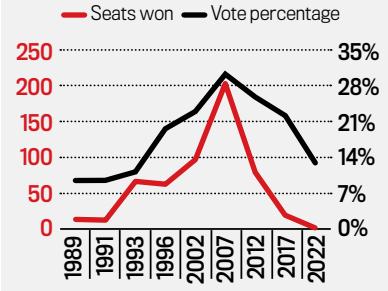
As a BSP zonal coordinator explains, "The party's strategy was that in seats where the SP did not have a Muslim candidate, the Muslim voter would vote for the BSP's Muslim candidate." As it turned out, BSP's Muslim candidates found themselves pitted against fellow Muslims from the SP or allies in 48 seats. In 37 seats, Muslim voters unilaterally voted for the SP; the vote was split in another 11, to the BJP's advantage. Former BSP heavyweight who is now in Congress, Naseemuddin Siddiqui, says: "Mayawati gave tickets to Muslim candidates in such a way that they could help the BJP candidates win by dividing the votes." Mayawati herself said that Muslims had made a costly mistake by going with the SP. "Had the Muslim vote merged with that of the Dalits, we could have done in UP what the TMC did in West Bengal. But the Muslim shift to SP bred fear among BSP supporters, upper-caste Hindus and OBCs of a return to *jungle raj* if the SP came to power," she said after the result.

It was the shift in her traditional Dalit votebank, however, that cost Mayawati the dearest. To dent her Jatav Dalit vote, the BJP fielded Baby Rani Maurya, the former governor of Uttarakhand, from Agra, an erstwhile BSP stronghold. Alongside, Asim Arun, the former Jatav police commissioner of Kanpur, was made the BJP candidate from the Kannauj (reserved) assembly seat (he won). Says Ajay Kumar, "A large section of the pro-BSP Jatav voters supported the BJP this time. The BSP, which won two reserved seats in 2017, did not win a single one in 2022."

Exit polls had predicted the trend. Dalits constitute 21 per cent of the population in UP. The India Today-Axis My India exit poll reflected an increase of 10 percentage points in the Jatav vote for the BJP this time. The non-Jatav vote, too, drifted saffronwards—51 per cent of the non-Jatav Dalits likely voted for the BJP. In 2017, the corresponding number was 31 per cent, according to a CSDS (Centre for the Study of Developing Societies) estimate. The 20 percentage point increase in support resulted in an almost 2 percentage point growth in the BJP's vote share. According to Lokniti-CSDS, 65 per cent of Jatavs still voted for the BSP, but only 27 per cent of non-Jatav Dalits did in 2022.

## INTO THE TROUGH

*The BSP's assembly poll performance till date*




Where does the decline of the BSP leave the Bahujan Movement? Old-timers are worried about the BSP's rout and the future of the movement. Raj Bahadur, a founding member of the BSP who is no longer with the party, says, "Mayawati has ruined Kanshi Ram's mission. I left the BSP years ago after seeing her working for her own benefit. I formed a smaller outfit for the Bahujan Movement and am working to shape it as an alternative to the BSP."

Bhim Army's Chandra Shekhar Azad seemed to be the new face of the Dalit leadership for awhile, but the party's dismal showing— it could not even secure 1 per cent of the vote—has put paid to that hope for the time being. Azad himself lost his deposit in Gorakhpur where he contested against Yogi Adityanath.

The BSP, therefore, could again become a fulcrum of Dalit hope. "It's time we revamped the party," says a senior party functionary. "But first, we need to remove the impression that we are a B-team of the BJP." Prof. Badri Narayan of the Govind Ballabh Pant Social Science Institute in Prayagraj too underlines the need for the BSP to reinvent itself. "Politics," he says, "is a game of language and reinvention. *Naye zamaane ke hisaab se khud ko dhaalna hoga* (You will have to move with the times)." He also believes the party needs to prepare a second line of leadership without falling prey to dynastic succession. "If they can do these two things," he says, "there is some chance of them getting back in the game." It is imperative, not just for the party, but also for the future of the Dalit movement. ■